

Directing AI — Quick Card

*AI does **seven different jobs** in this method, and only one of them is drafting. Knowing which job you're asking for is most of the skill. Every prompt here is paste-ready; every one has a verification step, because **the AI advises** — **you decide and verify**.*

The seven jobs

Job	What you're asking for	When
TUTOR	explain something <i>to you</i>	any time, every section
WIDEN	what am I missing?	after you've drafted, before you commit
CHECK	test what I decided against a standard	after a draft exists
SIMULATE	be my student, so I can see it from their side	after a draft exists
TRANSLATE	change the form, add nothing	once content is final
CARRY	hold my decisions as standing context	from §1 onward, continuously
PRODUCE	draft the artifact	§6 / Week 4 only

Notice **PRODUCE** is last and alone. AI drafts nothing before Week 4 — that is *decisions before production*, not an oversight. Before then it checks, widens, simulates and tutors.

The job AI does NOT get: **ESTIMATE**. “How long will this take?” is the question it is worst at and most confident about. Use the Contact-Hour companion and your own measured pace.

Always available

TUTOR > “I’m a subject-matter expert, not an instructional designer. When I hit a term I don’t know — gradual release, altitude, scaffolding, UDL — explain it using **my own subject** as the example, and tell me which section it matters in.”

CARRY — paste once, at the start of every working session > “This is my Decisions doc. Treat it as fixed context for everything I ask from now on — don’t make me restate the audience, depth or tone.”

If a later draft contradicts your Decisions doc, the context slipped. Re-paste it.

Week 1 — objectives (Guide §1–§2)

WIDEN — what’s missing from my audience? > “My audience is [X]. Who else realistically ends up in this room, and what would they need that my description doesn’t cover?”

CHECK — the four traps > “Here are my objectives. For each, say which it falls into — instructor-focused, activity-not-learning, not measurable, inflated verb — or ‘none’. **Do not rewrite them.**”

The last sentence is the guardrail. Without it, it writes your objectives and the decision has left the room.

WIDEN — what objectives am I missing? > “My audience is [X], my goal is [Y], here are my objectives. What do courses like this usually include that I haven’t written? **Don’t rewrite mine.**”

*Input, not instruction. You do **not** have to add any of them — the job is to make sure you’re excluding things on purpose, not by accident.*

SIMULATE — is my objective ambiguous? > “Here is one objective. Write three different things a student might hand in as evidence they met it.”

*If what comes back isn’t what you had in mind, **the objective is ambiguous** — and you found out before anyone was assessed on it.*

Week 2 — audit, decompose, MDD (Guide §3–§4)

WIDEN — stuck on a practice > “I’m answering ‘[anchor question]’ for a course on [X]. Give me five concrete features other courses use. I’ll pick or reject.”

WIDEN — what modules am I missing? > “Here are my course objectives and my module list. What modules would a course like this usually have that I don’t? **Don’t reorganise mine.**”

SIMULATE — test the sequence > “You’re a student who just finished Module 3. Based only on that, what do you expect Module 4 to teach? What would confuse you if it came next?”

If its expectation doesn’t match your Module 4, your order has a seam.

CHECK — the trace-back test, run cold > “Here are my course objectives and my module list. Name any module that doesn’t trace to an objective, and any objective no module serves.”

For each flag: scope creep to cut, or an objective you forgot to write?

TRANSLATE — the syllabus falls out > “From this Decisions doc and MDD, draft the student-facing syllabus. Every fact must come from one of them.”

Week 3 — structure and access (Guide §5, §8)

WIDEN — make a vague activity buildable > “Module objective: [X]. My three rungs are [I do / we do / you do] = [Y]. Give me three concrete named activities for the ‘we do’ rung — each with what’s provided and what the student supplies. **Name them; don’t write them.**”

SIMULATE — find the missing rung > “Here’s my complete version and my practice version. You’re a student who has only seen the complete one. Attempt the practice. Where do you not know what to do?”

CHECK — portability > “Read this teaching guide as someone who has never taught this subject. List every place you’d have to improvise.”

*This is the real bar: could someone **else** teach it from the page alone?*

PRODUCE — alt-text for every visual > “Here is my module text and a list of its visuals with what each shows. For each, draft alt-text that conveys what the visual **teaches**, not just what it depicts.”

CHECK — the one-mode-only audit > “Flag any concept in these materials reachable only one way — only by reading, only by a diagram, only by hearing me say it.”

WIDEN — barriers I haven’t considered > “My module is [X] for [audience]. What access barriers should I be thinking about for this kind of material that I probably haven’t?”

TRANSLATE — captions and transcripts > “Turn this segment script into captions and this demo into a written transcript. **Add nothing that isn’t in the source.**”

Week 4 — produce (Guide §6)

This is PRODUCE’s week, and the Guide walks the loop step by step — set the persona, build the complete version, degrade it into practice, bound the answer space, verify every line. **Use §6a, not this card.** The two councils and the comprehensiveness check are in §6b and §6c.

Week 5 — evaluate (Guide §9)

SIMULATE — a pre-mortem, before you have real feedback > “You took this module and it didn’t work for you. You’re not hostile, just honest. What went wrong?”

A prompt for what to watch for — never a finding.

TRANSLATE — retro notes into real changes > “Here are my notes from the run. Turn them into specific changes, each naming the MDD row or module file it lands in. **Don’t propose anything my notes don’t support.**”

The two rules under all of it

You decide and verify. Every prompt above ends with something you check. “The AI wrote it” is never an excuse for an error, a stale fact, or a tone you’d never use.

Plausible is not correct. Two red flags tell you where to dig: **verbosity** (it won’t stop explaining) and **certainty** (hedge-free). Where it sounds most sure and over-explains, check hardest. (*Full card: Reviewing AI Output — Red Flags.*)